

Steel Door Conversion

To replace a standard threshold with an ADA-compliant threshold, here are the steps:

1. Place the door (hinges up) on a flat work surface, with the threshold end hanging off.
2. Drive out the hinge pins, remove the latch-side plug and screw, and remove the door from the frame. Save the plug and screw for Step 14. Set the door aside.
3. Remove weatherstripping from all three sides of door frame.
4. Measure from the outside top of the door frame down along each side, and mark on the frame at 80-3/4". Extend these marks onto the inside surface of the frame.
5. Install a cross brace on the door frame above the bottom hinge, using square-drive 1½" screws with big washers to secure the door frame. Position the brace so that the distance from the brace to the bottom of each door frame leg is the same.
6. Using a 2x4 block and a mallet, drive one end of the standard threshold out of the frame, and then gently pry it loose from the other side of the frame, leaving the bent staples in place. Remove the standard threshold assembly and save it for LIHI.
7. Pre-drill and countersink into the top brick-molding 1" from each end, and drive a 3" brown screw into the hole, to stiffen the corners.
8. Carry the frame to the back chop saw, and, with a helper, carefully position the frame so that you can cut one side of the door frame exactly at the mark (leave the mark). Reverse the frame, and cut the other side exactly on its mark.
9. Return the frame to the work table, and install the router guides on each of the door frame legs. (They are different, one is labeled "Hinge Side" and the other "Latch Side").
10. Use the end-cut router from the black cabinet, whose depth has been preset. Carefully insert it into the guide while it is running, to begin the cut through the door-stop. Cut down just far enough to clear the bottom edge of the door-stop, and remove the router.
11. Remove the routing guides, and place a tarp under the door frame legs. Using the rattle-can of Kilz primer, spray the cut surfaces. Allow to dry (30-60 min).
12. Using one of the pre-trimmed ADA thresholds (exactly 36" long), drill two clearance holes for #6 drywall screws, about ¼" in from the ends, and 1½" from one side. Remove the burrs from the opposite side.
13. Position the threshold so that the inner edge of the threshold is flush with the inner (upper) edge of the door frame, and with the clearance holes down. Drive a 1¼" drywall screw into each of the clearance holes, being careful to drive them straight in or slanted a little towards the outside of the door frame, so that the door-stop does not split.
14. Remove the cross brace from the frame, and reinstall the door. Drive in the hinge pins, and secure the door with the plastic peg and thumb screw that you saved at Step 2.